

The Commute-and-Coaching Trap: Mapping Time Poverty and Academic Productivity Among High School Students in Dhaka City.

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Submission Date: 13/08/2026

Abstract

How travel times and private coaching dependencies affect the study habits of English-Medium high school students (O/A-Level, N = 68) in Dhaka City is examined in this study. Using statistical analyses—including correlations, regressions, and t-tests—whether these daily pressures push students toward rote memorization was evaluated. The results show that while long commutes and heavy coaching schedules consume significant time, they do not directly cause students to rely on memorization ($R^2 < 0.002$). Instead, their effect is indirect: daily schedule pressures lead to severe sleep loss and mental stress, which then drive surface-level study tactics. Feeling overwhelmed predicted 25.0% of time-forced formula memorization ($r = 0.500$), while lack of sleep was the single largest factor, accounting for 57.0% of panic-driven memorization ($r = 0.755$). These patterns were consistent across both O-Level and A-Level students ($p > 0.05$). Overall, the findings show that urban lifestyle stress indirectly forces students into rote learning by causing burnout and sleep deprivation, highlighting a clear need to prioritize student health alongside educational reforms.

Keywords: Shadow Education, Time Poverty, Urban Commute, Rote Memorization, Academic Overwhelm, Sleep Deprivation, CAIE & Pearson Edexcel, Dhaka City Secondary Education

1. Introduction

In the highly competitive secondary education landscape of Dhaka, Bangladesh, students pursuing international curricula—such as Cambridge Assessment International Education (CAIE) and Pearson Edexcel—are subjected to intense academic performance pressure. These standardized international frameworks are explicitly designed to cultivate critical

thinking, analytical reasoning, and high-level conceptual mastery rather than rote retention [1]. However, to secure high grades on these high-stakes board examinations, students increasingly depend on commercial shadow education, including multi-subject private tutoring centers and personal coaching batches [2], [3]. Consequently, the daily routine of a typical secondary student in Dhaka has

